

Call #: AP2.S2 v.203 Mar-Apr 1931
Item Loc : LOVE Folio Available

Journal Title: Saturday evening post (1839)

Volume: April 4, 1931 Issue: April 4, 1931

Month/Year: April 1931

Pages: 66

Article Author: Helen Willis

Article Title: Tennis Impressions

ILL Number: -11567853

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TENNIS IMPRESSIONS

By Helen Wills

THERE was a tennis enthusiast on the Blue Train on his way to the Côte d'Azur, who was sitting by the open window, resting his hand on the sill. The lock had failed to catch and the window injured his fingers badly. He looked very happy, and said, "It's all right. I am glad to say it isn't my tennis hand."

The inhabitants of the tennis world, when you get to know them, are healthy people who spend a good deal of time running after balls, and who have lots of fun. At least they think they are having fun. Some players, mildly interested at first, become fascinated by the sport and gradually come to mold their lives about the game. Their movements from one place to another fall into the schedule of the tournaments. How could a game gain such a hold upon anyone, you might ask. For a year in Europe I followed the schedule, and I can well understand it. It is a restless existence, in a way, but who is it that does not like a changing and shifting scene? I found that there was never a moment that was not filled with interest, never a minute that became monotonous.

Stepping from college life, with its succession of eight o'clock classes, mid-term examinations and routine happenings, I was perhaps just in the right frame of mind to enjoy the activities of European tennis. And may I say here, without meaning to cast any reflections upon our tournaments, that for an American who has already done the home tournaments the foreign tournaments offer more entertainment? One reason is because the scene is new; another reason is that one meets many excellent European players who never come to America. A third reason is that the standard of women's tennis is higher. Why this is so I do not know, but it is true that almost every player that one meets in a tournament abroad is very steady, even if her game doesn't happen to be a speedy one.

How a Lob Becomes a Drop Shot

OUR American women are more inclined to play a faster game, but an unsteady one. This is why most of our players are swept off the courts when they go abroad for the first time. An American abroad, meeting in the first round an Englishwoman or a German who can put the ball back twenty or thirty times without wavering, is completely taken by surprise.

I have played tennis for eleven years and

have just reached the point where I am beginning to understand a little bit about the principles of the game. You can't have the greatest enjoyment out of the sport until you are partly able to know where your ball is going to go. You can think up fine schemes in your mind, and then not be able to make them work. When someone comes up to you after a match and says "Fine strategy, marvelous tactics," you must puff out your chest and pretend you know what they are referring to, because it usually is true that the person who is the most surprised about it, besides your opponent, is yourself. Many times you can't remember having made a particular shot at all, and at other times you hide the shameful secret that the lovely drop shot that has been admired really was supposed to have been a lob, but nicked

the wood on your racket and turned instead into a short shot just over the net. Club dubs are not ashamed to thank the wood for a winning shot, but did you ever hear a so-called good player who was grateful? After a remarkable wood shot that wins him the point, he pretends he had it all thought out, and twirls his racket or pulls up his sleeves or adjusts his eye shade.

Now that the subject of the eye shade has been brought up, something more should be said of this valuable adjunct to tennis. Besides holding up the hair and preventing crow's-foot wrinkles around the eyes, it does other things for the feminine competitor.

Hiding One's Worries Under an Eye Shade

IT SHADOWS her eyes so the opponent can't tell where she is looking, and so helps her to keep secret her strategy of the moment, if she has a strategy; and if she hasn't, the mysterious shadow makes her look as if she has, which is just as good. The other thing the eye shade does is to hide the facial expression of the player from the gallery and from the opponent. Suppose the player were behind one set, and her opponent were leading thirty-love, five-love in the second set. Maybe she would look worried, and maybe this would be just what the opponent needed to encourage her to smash her next ball for an ace. But the eye shade hides the worried look, makes the player underneath it appear brave instead.

The simplicity of tennis, when expressed in the above terms, is astounding to the person who has just completed a book by the world's greatest strategist, with the title, *Psychological Aspects of Ball Rotation*. The remarkable thing is that the better the player, the more simple the game appears. Suzanne Lenglen seemed to be in the A B C stage. The fuss and fury of tennis all belong to the beginner. If you see a player who looks as if he is working hard, then that means he isn't very good. If it gets to the point where spectators complain that he isn't interesting, that means that he never makes any mistakes. Rene Lacoste was so good at tennis that people began to

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The Author With Her Husband, Frederick Moody, Jr., and a Group of Friends on a Yachting Cruise. Mr. Moody is Shown at the Right With Pipe

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Helen Wills in Her Art Class at the University of California. In Addition to Her Tennis Activities, the Many-Times Champion is Proficient With the Pencil and Brush

TENNIS IMPRESSIONS

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think he wasn't any good at all. In terms of philosophy, he had reached the infinite, and got beyond the attention of the average spectator who goes to a game to get a thrill.

Thrills, like laughs, depend upon the unexpected. The dopesters in the sport sheet predict a big upset, and in hopes of seeing it come true, a large crowd turns out. The audience at tennis gets a thrill out of an amazing return, a surprisingly long or fast rally, an unaccountable pick-up, a surprise win. All these things are unexpected—at least, one doesn't quite know when any of them will happen.

No Tantrums in Tennis

Two matches on the Center Court at Wimbledon that are superexamples of the thrilling tennis game were William Tilden's defeat by Henri Cochet, in 1927, when the former lost, after leading at 5-2, two sets to nothing. The other was the defeat of Henri Cochet by Wilmer Allison in 1930, a totally unexpected happening. In the latter match, the young American was not conceded a chance of winning, and yet, before the astonished eyes of Wimbledon that day, he brought forth a game with which the Little Iron General could not cope.

No nice tennis player ever becomes angry on the court, or any sensible one, because he knows that an irritated frame of mind ruins his game more quickly than anything else. I discovered once that it is foolish to become cross on the court, either with oneself or with one's opponent. From the time that I had joined the Berkeley Tennis Club I had played on an average of at least once a week with a certain player who is a delightful opponent and a perfect sportsman. He was always a little bit better than I, so for seven years I had not been able to defeat him. When you try to defeat a person for seven years and never can quite do it, then perhaps you have an excuse for becoming discouraged, but I wasn't. I had thought every week for seven years that I was going to win, but this never happened. So, at the end of seven years, I began to think that my opponent was growing conceited about being able always to win our games. He probably was not, but after seven years of trying, you cannot blame anyone for getting into this frame of mind. So I let some well-meaning remark of his make me cross. The harder I tried, the poorer my game became. He won six-love, six-love; my worst score against him in seven years. I decided I would never give way to my temper again. Since then we have continued with our weekly games, which makes eleven years in all. The other day I won two straight sets, so I have one victory in eleven years to my credit. The one triumph wiped out the other ten years' defeats.

Great assets in match play are calmness and an even temper. Another thing that one should always remind himself of when he goes out on the court is that while there is life there is hope. Even though your opponent leads five-love against you, there is a chance for you to win the set, unless he happens to be Tilden or Lacoste. The match between Tilden and Cochet which was mentioned above illustrates this. Cochet never believes he is defeated until he is defeated. In his career in tournament play there are

games all along the way that he has won because he has not wavered in his belief that he could win.

There are many points which may be discussed concerning match play, such as: Why does a certain player never seem able to hold a lead? Why does another player never conquer nerves in match competition? Why do some players play well when no one is watching them, and not at all well when they have an audience? Why do onlookers inspire other players? Kathleen McKane Godfree, for example, was 25 per cent better in her Center Court matches than in her matches on any other court. The bigger the audience, the cooler Cochet.

All the people who go to Wimbledon do not go to watch the games. I have discovered, inside the grounds, school children who have paid their admission who don't care about watching the matches. They come for a different purpose. They are armed with autograph books. They take their stand at the players' entrance of the clubhouse and wait for their prey. I should not blame the school children, for I have an autograph book too. It all depends upon whether you are the hunter or the hunted. At least, I have never actually run after my autographer. Often when I have thought I have escaped the watchful eyes at the door, and have almost reached the court safely, I have heard pattering feet running behind, and full of resolution to refuse the hunters and be on time for my match, have been disarmed by smiling English eyes and rosy cheeks.

Kind Words From a Comedian

The school children are more intelligent than I, because they always carry their books with them and are prepared; but I never think of my book until I see the person whose signature I would like to have. My book is usually at home, three thousand or six thousand miles away, so it is then too late. But once it happened that I was at home and had my book with me, and someone came riding into town from off the Western range. He had a lock of hair hanging down over one eye

and looked out from under it rather sadly. Humorists always look sad. This one is called by many America's greatest. He does miracles with a rope. He wrote in my book, "Helen, you always got a comedian pulling for you." Maybe I should not have told what he wrote, but it is to show that you have to have a great sense of humor if you are willing to write in an autograph book. I have not given him away by telling his name.

How to Stay an Amateur

Now that I have started I shall go on and give some more secrets away. What do tennis players eat and how do they keep from being professionals? Tennis players' diet includes everything edible. None of them have diet lists which they follow. They often eat lobster and ice cream for luncheon when they have a match in the afternoon. This is not advisable if one is going to play at Forest Hills with the temperature at 90 degrees, but it is done. From my tournament-playing experience, I have decided that a diet is not necessary, but, instead, have a list of foods which are to be avoided just before a match. Included on this list are lobster, as well as fish of all kinds, pies, cake, cucumbers, radishes, hot breads, waffles, Yorkshire pudding, and, if in Germany, beer. One glass of beer suffices to induce sound sleep upon the tennis court. If the player does wake up for a stroke or two, he finds that his eye is just enough wobbly so that he doesn't hit his strokes cleanly. The precision that tennis demands makes necessary total abstinence—even from beer. Of this the tennis player is aware, as well as are competitors in other sports. The person who says one cocktail or one glass of beer doesn't make any difference in one's eye and coordination and balance is wrong—at least from a tennis point of view.

The other question which is to be exposed for the first time—it has never been discussed before—is: How does the tennis player keep from being a professional? The only way now open for the amateur to avoid professionalism is for him to be rolled in cotton

wool and moth balls between tennis seasons. Then, on the day of the first tournament, he can be delivered and unrolled in the presence of the committee and the press. In this way he will be protected from even the breath of scandal.

A question that has never been answered satisfactorily is this: "Do sports make women unfeminine?" About once a month, when questions are running low, somebody asks this one. They don't always put it in quite that form. Sometimes they make the statement, "Sports make women unfeminine." But the response is always the same—in that there is none. At least, hardly ever. Once I made a response. No one noticed it, but I did. It was to a statement made by one of the foremost theatrical producers of Broadway. He said that sports were making women unfeminine, which no one would have paid attention to, except that he is supposed to have the ability to choose for his productions the most beautiful American girls. He went on to say that sport made hard faces, unpleasant expressions, angular lines, bulging muscles. He added that the present standard of beauty has no place for the athletic girl. No one would listen to this who had indulged in golf or tennis or swimming or the other healthful outdoor diversions open to women. Sport and exercise in the fresh air are the very wine of life. But young school-girls who are beginning to take up sports, and who are just becoming aware that there are such things in the world as feminine charm and beauty, might easily think that the edicts of a Broadway beauty specialist are right and final. Anyone in the public eye who spreads misinformation to be gobbled up by the young is not giving much of a hand to those who are going to be the grown-ups of tomorrow. The chances are a hundred to one that a woman who has taken up a sport and had plenty of exercise will be, at fifty, far younger looking and healthier than she would have been if she had just sat. The fact that exercise keeps people young is enough in its favor to make every woman participate in sport, for youth is perhaps the most sought-after treasure in the world. Then, to its health-giving properties, add the fun, the pleasure and the exhilaration that sport provides, and you have something which, undeniably, makes this business of living a more joyful thing.

Tennis Headliners

Not all sportswomen are pretty; even in tennis there are a few players who are not beautiful. But it is because they were born that way and not because they took up tennis. I state very fiercely that tennis and other sports do not lessen feminine charm or pleasing appearance.

Who are the world's leading tennis players, and how should they be ranked? For safety's sake, I will not name a list of my own. Tennis players are sometimes touchy as to what other players think about them—I among the rest. The list belongs to A. Wallis Meyers, an English sports expert whose word on tennis is generally thought sound and accurate. He is brave enough each year to come out with a ranking. The men's ranking is:

1. Henri Cochet, France.
2. W. T. Tilden, United States.

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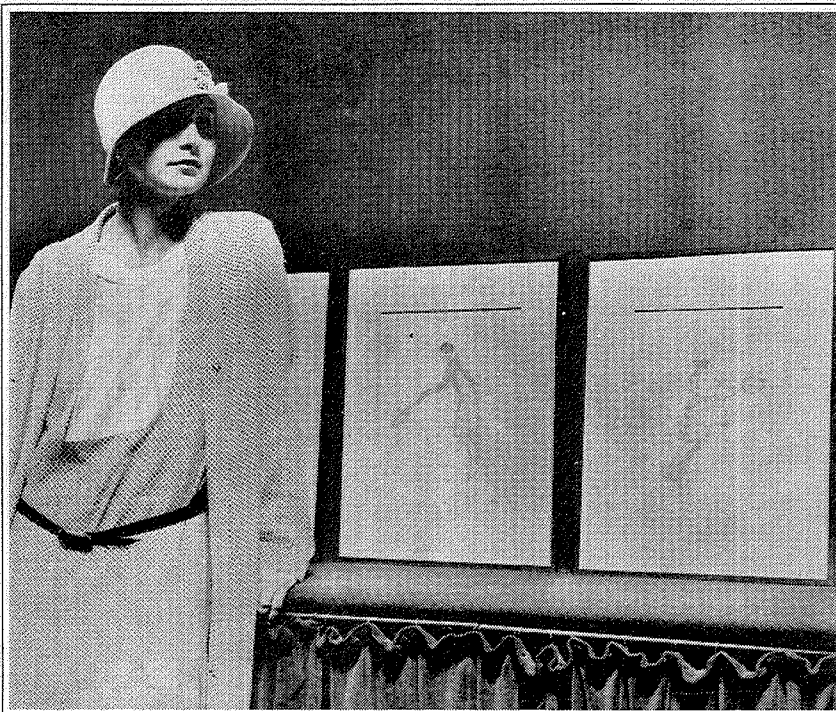


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Miss Wills at an Exhibition of Her Own Sketches, Held at a London Art Gallery

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3. Jean Borotra, France.
4. J. H. Doeg, United States.
5. Frank Shields, United States.
6. Wilmer Allison, United States.
7. G. M. Lott, United States.
8. H. L. De Morpurgo, Italy.
9. Christian Boussus, France.
10. H. W. Austin, England.

The reader will note that half of the first ten are Americans. William Tilden is ranked ahead of Johnny Doeg, although the latter won the United States championship. Tilden, however, won at Wimbledon, which was last year more representative than our own championships because all the leading European players, including Henri Cochet, were entered. Cochet did not play in the United States championship last year. Below jolly Jean Borotra rank four of the most promising young Americans, all of them under twenty-five years of age. The baby is Johnny Doeg, who proved that years had nothing to do with it by winning the singles championship with some splendid tennis. "One of the famous Suttons" is heard when his name is mentioned. His mother was one of the four Sutton sisters. They were all excellent players. Their games improved rapidly under the California sun. May Sutton—now Bundy—was the first American woman player to win the singles championship at Wimbledon.

Temperaments of Leading Players

As you may well imagine, there are all kinds of temperaments to be found upon the court. Each player is just as different from the others as are his strokes. There are serious players, quiet players, happy players, dashing and daring players. There are some who one day are gay and reckless and the next silent and conservative. Some see only the lines when they are in action and try to aim their ball for these narrow margins of safety. Other players would rather put a ball back forty times than take a chance.

For the fun of it, let us take the list of the first ten men players and try to give a little definition of each.

1. Henri Cochet, an iron general in miniature, with a handsome face, high brow, piercing brown eyes, strong chin, tight lips, who welcomes a dangerous and thrilling game on the court. Appeals to the crowd, but does not play to the gallery. Gives an impression of supreme confidence at all times. Has a sense of humor, but is not inclined to display feelings. Main points of game: Superb overhead smash, remarkable volley and unusual angles.

2. W. T. Tilden, an artist and actor on the court and off. Has keen sense of the dramatic at all times. Leads the spectator on into a frenzy of excitement. Expresses pleasure or disapproval, yet is sporting. Nervous temperament. Tall, very thin figure, but broad-shouldered. Court covering and service aided by these. Main points: Cannon-ball serve, beautiful execution of strokes, all-round perfection of game and clever strategy.

3. Jean Borotra, the jolly Basque. Happy and gay temperament, with instinctive knowledge of the way to make people laugh. Understands psychology of the crowd and can control outbursts of audience by a gesture or turn of the head. Unusually fine physique and remarkable lasting powers. Good-looking and well liked by everyone. Outstanding points in game: Net play with spectacular volleying from any position—even sitting down. On ground strokes his backhand is the strongest.

4. Johnny Doeg, baby champion of the United States. Picture of youthful good humor and exuberance. Boyish and engaging smile. Left-handed. Very brave and very tall. Fair-haired, bronzed, left shoulder two or three inches higher than right, developed through tremendous exertion of serving. Strongest points of game: Terrific serve and consistent good volleying, also lasting powers.

5. Frank Shields; also young, also tall and good-looking, strong. Chief rival of Johnny Doeg. Also tremendous serve, but right-handed. Supposedly more consistent on ground strokes than the champion. Attractive personality.

6. Wilmer Allison, fair-haired Texan of medium height and build. An all-round dependable. Hard worker and never beaten before the game is over. For example, his defeat of Henri Cochet at Wimbledon last June. Good-natured and not easily upset.

7. George Lott, Chicago. High-ranking for some years. Fair-haired and humorous. Great variety of strokes and tactics. Might defeat anyone on a good day. Greatly improved last season.

8. H. L. De Morpurgo, Italy. Handsome figure in action. Plays dashing and colorful game. Extremely steady European style. Has been called the perfect sportsman. Takes part in all the important tennis in England and on the Continent, but has not played in this country. Is able to make any champion play his best game. Strong points: Speed and beautiful driving.

9. Christian Boussus; one of the very young group in French tennis. Has not the confidence and steadiness of a Cochet, but has extremely graceful style, especially on the overhead. A quiet and unassuming player who will go far if his lasting powers are improved.

10. H. W. Austin, England; another of the younger players. Unusually graceful forehand, and steady game. Lacks stamina and aggressive net play at present. Considered as England's most promising player.

Ranking the Women

Mr. A. Wallis Meyers was even braver when he dared rank the women players. Here is the list:

2. Fräulein Ceile Aussem, Germany.
3. Mrs. Holcroft-Watson, England.
4. Miss Elizabeth Ryan, United States.
5. Mme. Renée Mathieu, France.
6. Miss Helen Jacobs, United States.
7. Miss Phyllis Mudford, England.
8. Señorita Lili de Alvarez, Spain.
9. Miss Betty Nuthall, England.
10. Fräulein H. Krahwinkel, Germany.

If I dared, I would add at about the middle of the list, the Baroness Von Reznicezk. She did not play in England last year, so perhaps that is why she is not ranked. She is a German player, nonspectacular, who is far better than she appears to be.

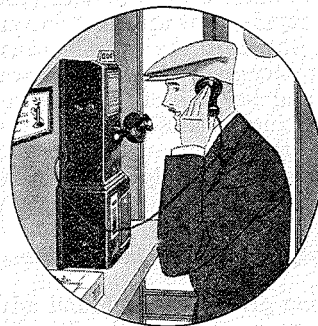
Among the ten named, perhaps the most promising is Mme. Renée Mathieu. She plays the fast modern game, is wonderfully all-round, and, except for lack of stamina, has the greatest talent of any of the foreign women players.

The most graceful player to watch on the court is Señorita Lili de Alvarez, who is outstanding, since Suzanne Lenglen's time, in beauty of stroke production.

Miss Elizabeth Ryan is the world's best doubles player. She has sixteen wins at Wimbledon in the doubles, a record unequaled by man or woman tennis player. She comes from California originally.

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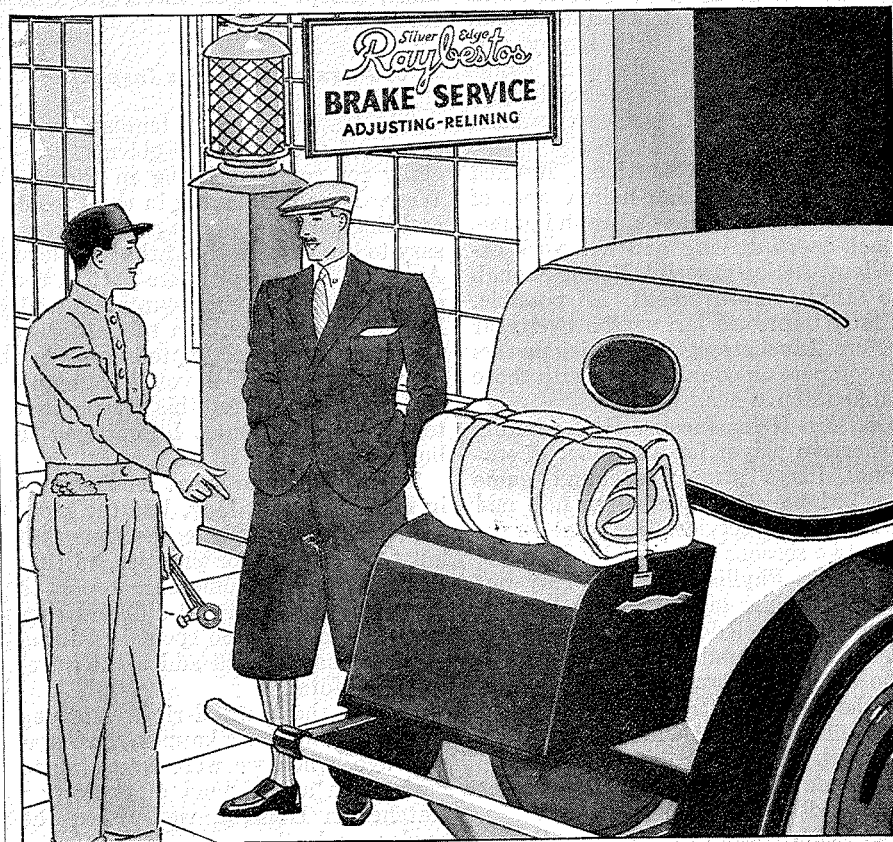
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In speaking quite frankly, may I be allowed to say that I believe women's tennis is more colorful than men's? It has not been considered so in this country, and this is probably true because we have had a few great men players who overshadowed everyone else. In England, however, at Wimbledon, women's tennis is just as popular as men's; probably because for so many years Suzanne Lenglen was the center of interest. I think, although women do not play so hard or so fast tennis, they are more entertaining to watch on the court because of their greater grace, their more charming ways, and because of their costumes. The floating lines of feminine dress in motion are more pleasing to the artistic eye than the severely cut uniform of the men players.

Analyzing the Women's Games

Having given this profound advantage to women players, I will now try to define briefly each of the leaders whom Mr. Meyers has given a world ranking.

2. Fräulein Cecile Aussem, Germany. One of the most attractive personalities upon the court, and the sweetest natured. Serious when engaged in a game, yet with a sense of humor. Extremely popular wherever she plays. Small, sturdy, dark-haired and dark-eyed. Resembles a dancing doll when in action, with white, pleated skirts fluttering about her. Strong points of game: Forehand drive, short cross-court backhand, extreme steadiness, fast court covering.

3. Mrs. Holcroft-Watson, England. Tall, slender, dark-haired, leader of English tennis. Generous sportswoman and very pleasant opponent. Strong points in game: Fine driving, especially fast on forehand, all-round steadiness and all-round speed. Fast court covering, intelligent tactics. Does not play at net.

4. Miss Elizabeth Ryan, United States. Famous doubles player. Well known on courts both here and abroad. Fine sportswoman, with happy personality. Noted for chopping game. Main points in play: Forehand chop, unusual amount of spin, excellent net work and drop shot.

5. Mme. Renée Mathieu. Ranked first in France. Fair-haired and of medium height. Plays all-round game. Back-court driving and net work excellent. Action graceful. Young enough so that improvement is possible. Vastly improved last season over year before. Must strengthen lasting powers to compete on equal footing with those ranked above her.

6. Miss Helen Jacobs. High-ranking American player for a number of seasons. Plays strong all-round game marked by steadiness. Has fast and low-bouncing service. Her game for the last two seasons impaired by illness.

7. Miss Phyllis Mudford. Tiny but sturdy English girl who caused sensation in Wimbledon tennis circles by defeating England's leading players in the Wightman Cup tryouts for position on the team. Has tremendous forehand drive, covers court with speed. Main strength lies in back court, as she does not come to net. Hard worker, never tires and never gives up.

8. Señorita Lili de Alvarez, Spain. Beautiful figure upon the court. Lovely face, unusual grace. Here is an example of an athletic woman who is both feminine and good to look upon. Other accomplishments: Speaks five languages, plays championship billiards, skates and skis exceedingly well. Should rank

higher than eighth, really, because she has the best style of any woman player. Did not do herself or her game justice this last season because of ill health. Strong points: Fine driving on a rising ball, both forehand and backhand, unusual court-covering ability, good volley.

9. Miss Betty Nuthall. The young English player who, though defeated in the qualifying rounds for position on the Wightman cups in England, won the United States singles title. The first Englishwoman to hold the American singles championship. An all-round player who on her best days plays very fine tennis. Best strokes—forehand and backhand drives.

10. Fräulein H. Krahwinkel. A tall, blond German girl with an all-round game which can be very good at times, but is not yet consistent. She will undoubtedly improve. Has good temperament, strong heart and nimble feet. Main points of game: Her drive, and speed of ball.

The list of the first ten women players is more international than that of the men. In the tournaments abroad, it is always very interesting to meet these various players and their friends. Unfortunately, none of them except the English can be induced to come to Forest Hills. One of the main reasons is that they have heard fearful stories of New York heat in August. "Oh, but it is so hot," is the answer when I have asked if they are coming to play. On warm days abroad—not nearly so hot days as we have during our tournaments—the foreign competitors appear to suffer from the heat. It is true with the English players, too, when they come to Forest Hills. They feel the heat more than we do. It is probably because their warm days during the tennis season are neither so frequent nor so oppressive as ours. I think we should solve the problem by having our national tournament in California. It would be sensible, too, because all the American participants at Forest Hills, except two or three, are Californians.

A Puzzled Customs Inspector

The traveling side of tennis playing is one of the biggest problems, especially for someone living in the Far West. If one is playing in the French and English championships, it is necessary to leave home about the middle of April. If the player takes part in the championships in this country as well, he then does not return to California until the middle of September. Five months have been devoted to tennis and travel. It is for this reason that tennis players cannot be engaged in business.

The actual time spent on the court in matches is not long, but the moving from place to place, the time that must be allowed for practice, so that the player can become accustomed to court, climate, food and different conditions, and the time spent in waiting between matches, all add up to a tremendous total.

During these wanderings amusing incidents sometimes happen. Two seasons ago, when we were returning to Paris from a week-end of exhibition matches in Holland, we crossed the border and the customs inspector came, as usual, to inspect the luggage. When he reached mine and discovered fifteen new tennis rackets and ten pairs of tennis shoes, some new, several scarcely worn, his eye turned upon me suspiciously. How could anyone in her right mind travel with fifteen tennis

rackets and ten pairs of shoes? She must either have robbed a sporting-goods store at The Hague, or else be engaged in transporting tennis rackets and shoes. She would have to explain. It was unusual, very strange and queer. Wasn't one racket enough for a tennis game? Duty must be paid on all these new goods. Another inspector arrived, who was of a more sporting frame of mind. He pulled out a newspaper on whose sport page the matches were described. "See there; this is the same tennis player!" The printed word subdued the first inspector's suspicion, and with a shrug of the shoulders he moved on to the other luggage.

Problems of Strange Courts

"Is it very difficult to become accustomed to the different courts when one travels about playing tennis?" This question is often asked the player. I think that the varying surface is the biggest problem of all, especially when the player is a beginner in tournament competition. Each court is different from any other, whether at home or abroad. At our tennis club in San Francisco we have asphalt courts—the most popular surface in California. Some of the courts were laid a year or so before the others. After playing on the newer surface and then changing to the older court, the difference in bound and playing quality is readily perceived. If courts of the same composition can vary so noticeably at one's home club, then you can imagine what a difference there is between asphalt and cement, and clay, and shell, and wood, and grass, and canvas.

There are, of course, other kinds of court surfaces, but the above-mentioned are the ones of which I can speak because I have played upon them. The courts most used out-of-doors are asphalt, clay and grass. Wood courts are popular for indoor winter play. Lately, in the eastern part of the United States a number of private indoor courts have been built with a clay surface. This is the most satisfactory kind of court for winter play, and is delightful for tennis. With an absolutely true surface, perfect lighting, and no wind or changes of temperature, the player enjoys his game under ideal conditions.

I remember so clearly the very first time that I played a match on a grass court. It was at Providence, Rhode Island, at the old Agawam Hunt Club. The courts there are very good, green, smooth and velvety. It had been raining, however, and as the turf was softer than usual, the balls were bouncing very low. The courts at the Berkeley Tennis Club, in California, where I had learned to play, are of asphalt, and the ball bounds high. I remember that I was a bewildered little girl with pigtails flying wildly as I rushed after the low-bouncing balls that damp morning at Agawam. Having had little experience in tournament play, I did not try to figure out why I was having a difficult time. I have since found that the first day on a new court surface is a somewhat confusing one for any player, whether he is experienced or not. It is true, however, that as you travel about, you learn how to adjust your game with greater ease to the different kinds of courts.

The important thing is to watch closely the bound of the ball. See whether it comes off the court faster or more slowly than the ball to which you have become accustomed at home. Then try to time your stroke so that it fits in with the new tempo of the ball.

The eye must be glued on the fast-revolving sphere. It is not unusual to see the very best players, when new to a court, nonchalantly swing for a ball and miss it entirely because they have forgotten for a moment that the timing is different. William Tilden is, perhaps, the most clever of any player in adjusting his game to a new court. Suzanne Lenglen used to change over to the grass courts of Wimbledon from the hard clay of the French courts, allowing herself only three or four days before the English championship. This meant, of course, that she had absolute confidence in her ability to become adapted to the new surface in this short period. She was perhaps the most scientific tennis player of all time. Her poise, personality, balance and mental alertness on the court are unique in tennis history.

Why was Suzanne Lenglen such a wonderful player? Firstly, she was suited both physically and mentally to the game and, secondly, she gave a great deal of her time to it. She was playing at her best at the moment when she retired from the amateur ranks. As you looked out upon the court and followed her flawless game, you saw a medium-tall, well-proportioned young woman, strong and wiry, yet slender. The constant exercise of tennis had developed no ugly muscles; in fact, she was as slender as was demanded by the fashion of the time. This is an argument in favor of tennis in response to those who claim that sport makes the feminine figure ugly. Mlle. Lenglen, after playing tennis since she was a child, possessed a form to be envied by any woman. Along with the well-proportioned and symmetrical figure which is always an asset in any sport, Mlle. Lenglen has a certain grace and ease in movement which are unusual.

The Incomparable Suzanne

Although hundreds of women are playing tennis, no one has appeared with quite this same grace in motion. Court covering and stroking appeared to be effortless for her. Part of this, of course, was due to her ability for coordinating eye and muscle. All the qualities necessary for good tennis seemed to be added together. Her strokes were good because she used the correct form, and because they were done gracefully. It seems unfortunate to have to use the past tense in speaking of this famous player, for she is now only a year or so more than thirty, and could, if she wished, still be enjoying the game.

When I saw her in Paris last spring, she said she had become tired of playing and had not touched a racket for two years; nor had she been a spectator at any of the tournaments. I asked her if she thought she might take it up again, and she said perhaps, although she had given it no thought. Some time later, I noticed, however, that she had attended the Davis Cup matches; so, perhaps, this indicates a reawakening of interest in the game on her part.

Followers of the game who did not see Suzanne Lenglen play at the height of her glory have indeed missed a wonderful experience. Perhaps it is better, in a way, that everyone did not, because after watching her, others appear to be playing only medium-good and rather unexciting tennis. Now Mlle. Lenglen has the status of a professional but is not engaged in the usual business of professionals—namely, that of teaching other people to play tennis.